

▶ A MASSIVE 'HEAD'ACHE

England came into the opening Ashes Test in Perth with a genuine chance of striking early against a depleted Australian side. After the first day and a little into the second, it appeared poised to make that advantage count and claim its first Test win in Australia in over 14 years.

Instead, England contributed significantly to its own undoing. A failure to press home the advantage in the third innings meant it set Australia a challenging but far from insurmountable target of 205. What followed was emphatic.

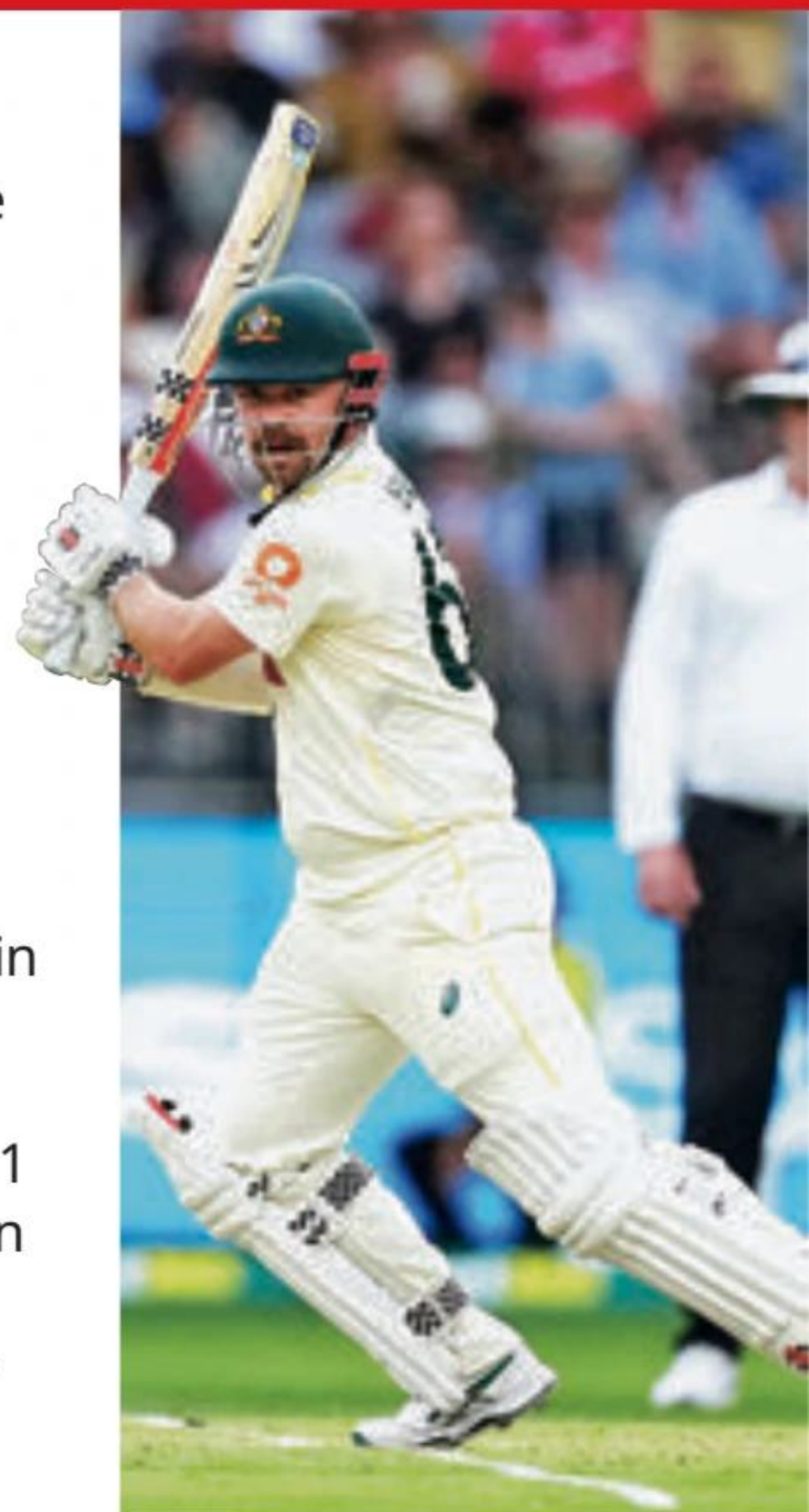
"Shell-shocked" was how England captain Ben Stokes later described it. An injury to

regular opener Usman Khawaja opened the door for Travis Head to move to the top of the order, and he seized the opportunity with devastating effect. Head tore into England's attack, dismantling Jofra Archer, Brydon Carse, Mark Wood and Stokes with disdainful ease.

The left-hander bludgeoned 123 off just 83 deliveries in a tone-setting innings that reshaped the series. Australia cruised to the target inside 30 overs, sealing victory in just two days and taking a 1-0 lead.

"That innings was out of this world," stand-in captain Steve Smith said later. "One of those days when he's on, and he got us home."

As Australia wrapped up the series inside 11 days to retain the urn, both sides will reflect on Perth as the decisive turning point. Head's assault did more than win a Test. It effectively sealed England's fate on the tour.



▶ TEARS AND TRIUMPH

India scripted history by clinching the inaugural Blind Women's T20 World Cup title, defeating Nepal by seven wickets in the final at the P. Sara Oval in Colombo.

After restricting Nepal to 114 for five, India made light work of the chase, overhauling the target in just 12.1 overs. Phula Saren starred with a fluent 44 off 27 balls, steering her side home in a commanding finish. Such was India's control in the final that Nepal managed just one boundary across its innings. The triumph capped a flawless campaign. India went unbeaten through the tournament, overcoming Sri Lanka, Australia, Nepal, the USA and Pakistan in the league phase before defeating Australia again in the semifinal to seal the silverware.

Coming just three weeks after India's maiden Women's

ODI World Cup triumph, the visually impaired team's success marked another watershed moment for women's sport in the country. Led by Karnataka's Deepika TC, the 16-member squad drew players from nine states — Karnataka, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh, Odisha, Delhi, Assam and Bihar — reflecting both diversity and depth.

Many of the players hail from modest rural backgrounds, and their rise to the world stage has brought renewed visibility and recognition to disability cricket in India. The victorious squad received a rousing welcome in Chennai and Bengaluru, and later met Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi and cricket legend Sachin Tendulkar.

"This moment will stay with us for life," Deepika said after the meeting. "It will motivate us to work even harder and carry Indian cricket to greater heights."

